



**STATE OF MARYLAND
DEPARTMENT OF HUMAN SERVICES (DHS)
REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS (RFP)
CUSTOMER SERVICE CENTER
RFP NUMBER OS/CSC-22-001-S**

ISSUE DATE: 8/1/2023

NOTICE

A Prospective Offeror that has received this document from a source other than eMarylandMarketplace (eMMA) <https://procurement.maryland.gov> should register on eMMA. See **Section 4.2**.

**MINORITY BUSINESS ENTERPRISES ARE ENCOURAGED TO
RESPOND TO THIS SOLICITATION.**

VENDOR FEEDBACK FORM

To help us improve the quality of State solicitations, and to make our procurement process more responsive and business friendly, please provide comments and suggestions regarding this solicitation. Please return your comments with your response. If you have chosen not to respond to this solicitation, please email or fax this completed form to the attention of the Procurement Officer (see Key Information Summary Sheet below for contact information).

Title: Customer Service Center
Solicitation No: OS/CSC-22-001-S

1. If you have chosen not to respond to this solicitation, please indicate the reason(s) below:

- ☐ Other commitments preclude our participation at this time
- ☐ The subject of the solicitation is not something we ordinarily provide
- ☐ We are inexperienced in the work/commodities required
- ☐ Specifications are unclear, too restrictive, etc. (Explain in REMARKS section)
- ☐ The scope of work is beyond our present capacity
- ☐ Doing business with the State is simply too complicated. (Explain in REMARKS section)
- ☐ We cannot be competitive. (Explain in REMARKS section)
- ☐ Time allotted for completion of the Proposal is insufficient
- ☐ Start-up time is insufficient
- ☐ Bonding/Insurance requirements are restrictive (Explain in REMARKS section)
- ☐ Proposal requirements (other than specifications) are unreasonable or too risky (Explain in REMARKS section)
- ☐ MBE or VSBE requirements (Explain in REMARKS section)
- ☐ Prior State of Maryland contract experience was unprofitable or otherwise unsatisfactory. (Explain in REMARKS section)
- ☐ Payment schedule too slow
- ☐ Other: _____

2. If you have submitted a response to this solicitation, but wish to offer suggestions or express concerns, please use the REMARKS section below. (Attach additional pages as needed.)

REMARKS:

Vendor Name: _____ Date: _____

Contact Person: _____ Phone (____) ____ - _____

Address: _____

E-mail Address: _____

STATE OF MARYLAND
DEPARTMENT OF HUMAN SERVICES (DHS)
KEY INFORMATION SUMMARY SHEET

Request for Proposals	Services - Customer Service Center
Solicitation Number:	OS/CSC-22-001-S
RFP Issue Date:	8/1/2023
RFP Issuing Office:	Department of Human Services (DHS or the "Department")
Procurement Officer: e-mail: Office Phone:	Sang Kang 311 W. Saratoga Street, 9 th Floor; Baltimore, MD 21201 Sang.kang@maryland.gov 410-767-7404
Proposals are to be sent to:	Submit Via eMMA https://emma.maryland.gov . Instruction on how to submit proposals via eMMA can be found at https://procurement.maryland.gov/wp-content/uploads/sites/12/2021/01/5-eMMA-QRG-Responding-to-Solicitations-Double-EnvelopeRFP.pdf
Pre-Proposal Conference:	8/8/2023 2:30 PM Local Time Virtual Pre-Proposal Conference through Google Meet See Attachment A for directions and instructions.
Questions Due Date and Time	8/22/2023 <u>9/8/2023</u> <u>9/26/2023</u> 5:00 PM Local Time
Proposal Due (Closing) Date and Time:	9/8/2023 <u>9/22/2023-10/6/2023</u> 5:00 PM Local Time Offerors are reminded that a completed Feedback Form is requested if a no-bid decision is made (see page iv).
MBE Subcontracting Goal:	45% <u>25%</u> with no subgoals
VSBE Subcontracting Goal:	1%
Contract Type:	Firm Fixed Price Indefinite Quantity Contract (COMAR 21.06.03.06(2))
Contract Duration:	Five (5) year base period after a six (6) month Transition-In period
Primary Place of Performance:	As proposed by Offeror
SBR Designation:	No
Federal Funding:	Yes

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1 Minimum Qualifications

1.1 Offeror Minimum Qualifications

There are no Offeror Minimum Qualifications for this procurement.

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2 Contractor Requirements: Scope of Work

2.1 Summary Statement

- 2.1.1. The Department is issuing this Request for Proposals (RFP) in order to acquire contractual services from a single Contractor to implement, operate and manage a Customer Service Center (CSC) for inbound and outbound communications of the Department.
- 2.1.2. CSC services include live operator and Interactive Voice Response Services (IVRS), for receiving and responding to inquiries via telephone. In addition, services include response to inquiries received via facsimile, electronic mail using a DHS email account and U.S. mail. Additionally, a tracking and reporting system is required to provide reports of the types and number of Customer contacts received and resolved on behalf of the Department. CSC services will be utilized by all DHS Administrations Statewide, notably the Central Office and the Local Departments of Social Services (LDSS) and Child Support offices located in all 24 jurisdictions in Maryland.
- 2.1.3. It is the State's intention to obtain goods and services, as specified in this RFP, from a Contract between the selected Offeror and the State.
- 2.1.4. The Department intends to make a single award for RFP. See RFP **Section 4.9 Award Basis** for more Contract award information.
- 2.1.5. An Offeror, either directly or through its subcontractor(s), must be able to provide all goods and services and meet all of the requirements requested in this solicitation and the successful Offeror (the Contractor) shall remain responsible for Contract performance regardless of subcontractor participation in the work.

2.2. Background, Purpose and Goals

The Department is the State's human services agency and serves over one million people annually (Customers). The Department aggressively pursues opportunities to assist people in economic need, provide preventive services, and protect vulnerable children and adults. Services are provided by staff within three (3) major Administrations and various supporting administrations and divisions throughout the State of Maryland, at the LDSS offices located in each of Maryland's 24 jurisdictions, in standalone child support offices, and the central office. Refer to **Appendix 3 – Administrations Programs Overview** for further details on DHS Administrations and their respective requirements.

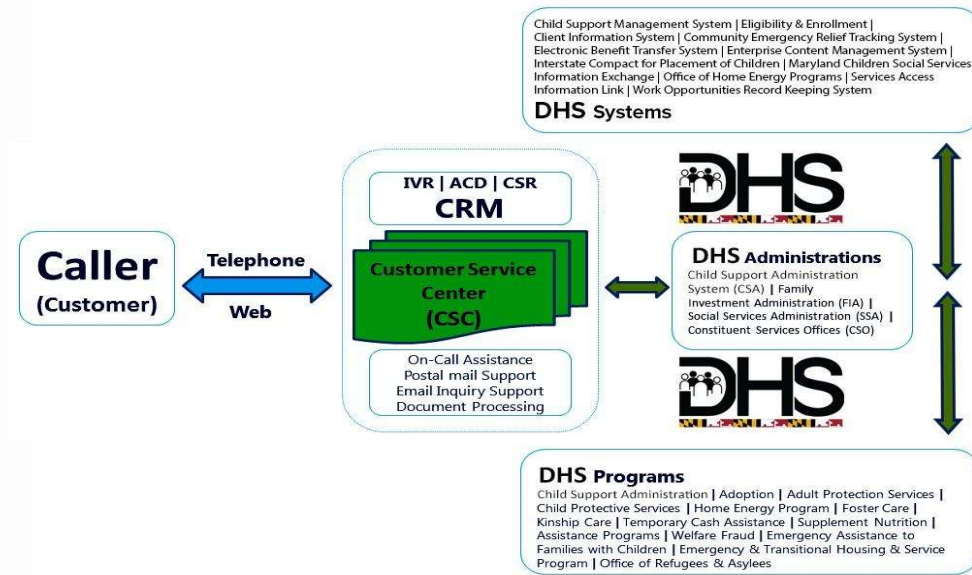
Effectively providing services to Customers requires continuous communication (verbal, electronic and written) and the ability to respond to both general and specific inquiries pertaining to critical and emergent needs. DHS continues to look for ways to provide more effective and efficient responses to Customer inquiries while maintaining the quality of its Customer experience. By applying innovative solutions to increasing Customer service and access to Customer's Case information through a dedicated and specialized CSC, DHS staff will be able to devote their time to more complex casework focusing on positive outcomes for Customers. To that end, Offerors are encouraged to describe those innovative services and technologies as part of their Proposal for initial implementation, given they do not have a negative impact on the Transition-In schedule or overall cost. Any optional services or technologies, which could be implemented in a future Task Order Request (see RFP Section 2.5) shall be included in the response to the Scope of Work.

The DHS programs are supported by a number of systems listed in Figure 1. Calls are managed through various options depending upon program needs. The Contractor shall implement requirements for all programs (CSA, FIA, SSA, and CSO) listed in the RFP during the Transition-In.

The average total volume of calls and communication for all the services offered by the DHS CSC is in excess of 200,000 calls per month (see **Appendix 4**). Call volume may include both Tier 1 and Tier 2 calls. Tier 1 calls are those calls seeking assistance or information that does not require the Customer Service Representative (CSR) to update any customer information within the Child Support Management System (CSMS) or the Eligibility and Enrollment (E&E) System, which are managed by DHS. Tier 2 calls may require the CSR to make limited updates within CSMS and/or E&E System. Although the State believes that the call volumes and statistics are factual, it makes no warranty that the information is either accurate or error-free. Where projections are provided, they are estimates prepared by the State for its own use, but the State makes no warranty with respect to the data on which the projections are based or that future experience will conform to the projections.

The Contractor will have access to DHS' existing toll-free telephone number for both in-state and out-of-state callers. The toll-free number will not be transferred to the Contractor. **The Contractor will need to implement and manage an IVRS for this Contract.** ~~In addition, the Contractor will have access to the DHS IVRS.~~ The initial point of contact for all telephone inquiries will be through an IVRS. The Contractor will work with DHS Administrations in understanding, developing, and implementing appropriate call tree structures and scripts. The IVRS will include automated services to enable the State to deliver unattended services 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, 365 days per year (366 days for leap year), in accordance with DHS approved scripts and routing paths; input options via telephone touch-tone pad and voice commands to access pre-recorded information (SEI); and speech recognition (speech -to text and text-to -speech technologies to enhance efficiency and customer service. Finally, the Contractor will **need to implement and manage a** ~~utilize the Department's~~ Customer Relationship Management System (CRM) to document customer inquiries and, as necessary, forward work orders to LDSS. ~~Both the DHS CRM and IVRS tools will be available to the Contractor to utilize and will need to be managed during the Contract period.~~

Figure 1: This chart shows DHS' overall vision of the CSC operations and how it will interface with the Department's information technology systems, Administrations and programs. This figure is not representative of the total scope of work outlined in this RFP.



2.2.1. Project Goals

- A. Decrease call wait time and improve Customer access to the Department and case information.
- B. Reduce the amount of time staff spends on routine tasks through effective and faster responses to Customer inquiries.
- C. Increase Customer service and access to Customer's case information through a specialized CSC, that provides effective and efficient Customer service solutions.
- D. Innovative ideas, practices, technologies, cost sharing and other services aimed at improving Customer services and generating a positive return on investment (ROI).

2.2.2. State Staff and Roles

In addition to the Procurement Officer and Contract Monitor, the Contractor will interact with the following State staff:

- A. DHS Program Liaisons
 - 1) A representative for each DHS Administration who will be responsible for Program and policy updates.
 - 2) Office of Technology and Humans Services (OTHS) Program Liaison will provide guidance and updates to DHS systems.

2.2.3. Other State Responsibilities

- A. Provide required information, data, documentation, and test data to facilitate the Contractor's performance of the work and will provide such additional assistance and services as is specifically set forth.
- B. Provide the current DHS toll-free number for access to the IVRS.
- C. ~~Grant necessary access and training to the DHS CRM to allow the Contractor to perform duties included in this RFP.~~

- D. Upon receipt of access request, provide access to DHS systems to allow the CSC the ability to receive pertinent information to address inquiries received via internet and telephone calls.
- E. Provide initial training on DHS policies, procedures, programs and major DHS systems.
- F. Provide troubleshooting and technical assistance through the DHS Help Desk for many major DHS applications or systems between the hours of 7:00 am and 7:00 pm, Local Time, Monday through Friday and 8:00 am and 12:00 pm on Saturday.
- G. Provide the current call scripts and develop the call scripts and/or screens.
- H. Provide pre-approval of all material used in all projects.
- I. Provide the Administrative Desk Reference, which is a detailed guide on all functional aspects of the Administrations that the CSC shall support.
- J. Provide an initial supply of 1,000 program applications in English and Spanish, with additional supplies provided upon request to the Contract Monitor.
- K. Supply DHS brochures in English and Spanish, with additional supplies provided upon request of the Contract Monitor.

2.3. Responsibilities and Tasks

2.3.1. General Requirements

The Contractor shall:

- A. Implement and manage a CSC to handle inbound and outbound calls for the Department, which incorporates **Contractor-provided** the Department's IVRS, **ACD** and CRM.
- B. Provide Customer assistance services on Departmental inquiries, program and case information.
- C. Provide technical and management staff in order to implement and operate the CSC.
- D. Provide support for Customer inquiries of varying complexity, including making appropriate referrals for additional assistance when the CSR is unable to fully resolve inquiries.
- E. Maintain enough staff to respond to Customer calls during Normal Business Hours, peak hours, and periods of heavy call volumes, except on State Holidays and weather-related or other emergency closures declared by the Governor and approved by DHS (Refer to <https://dbm.maryland.gov/employees/Pages/StateHolidays.aspx> and <https://dbm.maryland.gov/employees/Pages/WeatherRel.aspx>).
- F. Evaluate weekly the sufficiency of the number of telephone lines installed and the number of CSR's available to meet the call needs as call volumes increase. As needed, due to an increase in call volume, and at the Contractor's expense, install additional lines, equipment and/or CSRs to meet the call response timeline requirements.
- G. Handle spikes in call volume and meet Service Level Agreements (SLAs) as defined in **Section 2.6**. The plan for the management of such instances shall be due no later than thirty (30) Days after Notice to Proceed (NTP) and must be approved by the Contract Monitor.
- H. Identify only as and use the State's and DHS's names and logos on all correspondence, documents and information distributed to CSC Customers.

- I. Have the ability to communicate in other languages via utilization of a language line interpreter service.

2.3.2. Interactive Voice Response System (IVRS)

The initial point of contact for all telephone inquiries will be through an IVRS. **The Contractor shall provide the IVRS for this Contract. The IVRS shall be both traditional and conversational / dynamic.**

The Contractor shall:

- A. Ensure Direct Inward Dial line-Extension numbers (DIDs) are properly assigned to agents and administer the DID assignment upon on-boarding agents.
- B. Provide agents in accordance with skills matrix and queuing/routing requirements in the Automatic Call Distribution (ACD) system.
- C. Provide professional voice recording of IVRS Scripts in English and Spanish.
- D. Support Self Service Options, including directions, hours of operation, and available case information.
- E. Generate automated Customer Satisfaction Surveys to rate CSC and DHS performance. The survey shall be offered via telephone following a Customer call and shall be accessible via web or phone.
- F. Provide remote announcement updates for special situations (snowstorm, building emergencies, etc.).
- G. Provide hour by hour reports and twice daily benchmark (noon, end of day) email reports of IVR statistics, which shall include in-queue wait time, call back feature wait time, abandonment rate, call volume, average call handling time, and statistics on CSRs login time and call statistics.
- H. **The Contractor shall ensure that the IVRS integrates to the MD THINK-hosted DHS applications (CJAMS, CSMS, E&E, etc).**
- I. **The Contractor shall also provide that the IVRS is an industry standard product that allows for transferability of the IVRS data and system to MDTHINK (or be host-able by MDTHINK) or to another vendor at the end of the Contract.**

2.3.3. Customer Relations Management System (CRM)

The Contractor shall provide a vendor-hosted CRM for this Contract, which provides user access or licenses for approximately three thousand two hundred (3,200) users as designated by DHS. The Contractor shall ensure that the CRM integrates to the MD THINK-hosted DHS applications (CJAMS, CSMS, E&E, etc). The Contractor shall also provide that the CRM is an industry standard product that allows for transferability of the CRM data and system to MDTHINK (or be host-able by MDTHINK) or to another vendor during the Transition-Out period.

The Contractor shall:

- A. Train staff on the functions of the ~~DHS CRM, a web-based system.~~
- B. Use the CRM to record and update basic Customer information within the CRM, track all calls, activities, and operations of the CSC and use the data to identify Customer inquiry trends.
- C. Ensure CSRs use ~~DHS~~ **the** CRM as the primary system for all CSC activity.
- D. Determine secured role-based privilege settings of staff, while adhering to DHS' CRM user access roles capabilities. The Contractor shall ensure that DHS Security Monitors have the ability to reset user access based on the user's security profile and staffing level.
- E. Utilize scripts in the CSC provided by DHS programs. DHS will maintain control of the scripts/and or desk guides for dissemination.
- F. Forward Work Orders that are generated in the CRM when the Customer inquiry needs additional follow-up from DHS staff/LDSS are forwarded to local offices. The Contractor shall ensure that the service requests and Work Orders are consistent and have uniform narrative per the Administration Desk Guide.
- G. NOT delete any records in the CRM. Please refer to Section 24 of Attachment M.
- H. **Ensure that the CRM system has Dashboard, Business Intelligence and visualization capabilities.**

2.3.4. Automated Call Distribution (ACD) and Automated Dialer System

The Contractor shall provide an ~~a DHS will provide access to the Contractor to the~~

Department's ACD system, which has the capability to distribute incoming calls to CSRs. Call routing is based on sequence of arrival/origination, inquiry type, CSR availability, skills, and language fluency or other pre-defined routing instructions.

The Contractor shall:

- A. Comply with call routing and queuing based on specific requirements of DHS and the IVRS.
- B. Use the ACD to gather and report statistics in real-time, to include number of calls in queue, current hold time, maximum hold time, abandoned/dropped calls, average wait time, call volumes, live Customer calls, and any CSC activity at all times. The Contract Monitor and designees shall have access to the ACD at any time and without prior notice.
- C. Provide Customers with an estimated wait time and other recorded messages. Estimated wait time shall be offered at the beginning of hold time and repeated at various increments. The Callers must be given option to stay in queue or select the Call-back option during Normal Business Hours. The ACD shall prompt the caller to provide the Call-back information and provide an estimated Call-back time to the caller.
- D. Ensure that Outbound Calls to callers opting for a Call-back are made at the estimated Call-back time. If the Call-back encounters a busy or no-answer condition, the Contractor shall repeat the Call-back for up to 2 additional attempts within two (2) Business Days. If the Call-back encounters a voicemail or answering service, leave a brief message indicating the purpose of the call with information on how to contact the CSC and no additional Call-back is required.
- E. Record all calls by CSRs and provide audio recordings of individual/Customer calls for review by the Contract Monitor no later than one (1) Business Day of the request.
- F. Provide alerts to the CSC Managers/Supervisors when the call center experiences unforeseen or drastic changes and anomalies in the CSC operational patterns, such as persistently long hold times, persistent call drops, persistent voice distortion, etc., that needs attention and intervention.
- G. Monitor CSR performance utilizing industry standard practices including 'listen', 'record', 'workgroup alert', 'transfer', 'join', 'whisper coaching' and 'grab' methods.
- H. **Provide automated outbound calling capabilities including preview, progressive and predictive dialers, campaign management, and call-back assistance reports.**

2.3.5. Customer Services Representative (CSR)

The Contractor shall:

- A. Provide enough staff to always meet the requirements of the RFP.
- B. Ensure that at least ten percent (10%) of the CSRs in the CSC are fluent in Spanish to meet the trend in inquiries made in Spanish.
- C. Ensure that the CSRs meet the following general requirements: